

where buyers and sellers of travel inventory may find trusted partners they could not find before, connect directly, and start doing business immediately. Winding Tree is not owned by anyone; it is controlled by the community of its participants. It uses different licenses for each category. For example, for smart contracts it uses AGPL (Affero General Public License), for libraries and code examples it is licensed by Apache 2.0, and for all the texts found in the platform it is licensed by the Creative Commons Attribution 4.0 International. In short, any establishment can install this technology and broach the infrastructure.

Winding Tree uses Ethereum technology, a public blockchain that is best suitable for smart contracts, which provides greater cost-effectiveness for travel industry partners. Eventually, customers and other stakeholders involved receive a better deal. Disintermediation, that is, cutting off the middlemen, reduces the total cost of servicing as Winding Tree acts as a bridge between the business and their customers. The high-profile airline groups that have signed deals with Winding Tree aim to eliminate intermediaries and the accompanying costs to create a decentralised marketplace. These include Air Canada, Air France, KLM, Air New Zealand, Austrian Airlines, Brussels Airlines, Etihad Airways, Eurowings, Germany based Hahn Air, Lufthansa, Swiss Air, and Swissport.

Winding Tree's CEO Maksim Izmaylov says that Hobo Hotel Stockholm, a member of the Nordic Choice Hotels group, was the first hotel to undertake hotel booking and reservation services using their latest blockchain technology to provide real-life use case and best-in-class services to their customers in the travel and hospitality space without charging commission fees. As the platform is open source and distributed, it generates boundless possibilities for customers who are looking for lower costs,

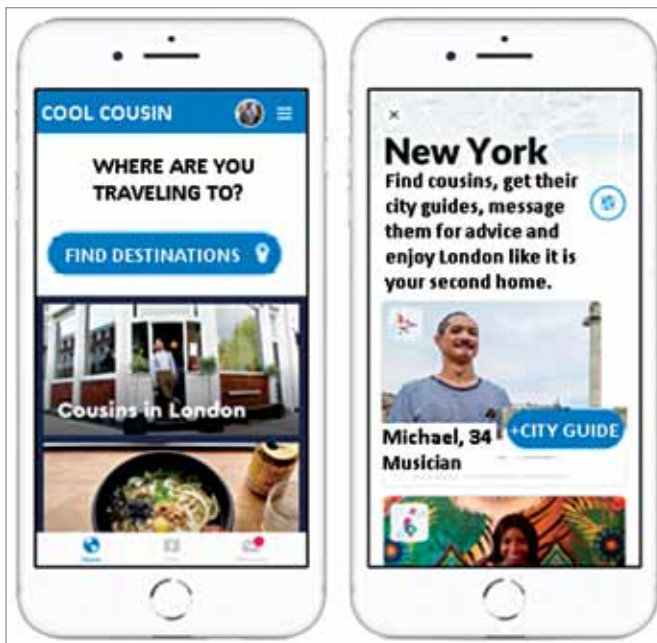


Fig. 3: Cool Cousin mobile app

Cool Cousin is a decentralised travel agency that has integrated the emerging blockchain technology to expand their business worldwide with the help of local experts in each city. These locals are known as 'Cousins' who love to share enough information about their city. Cool Cousin was set in motion with its curated travel experience during 2016 as a 16-person start-up, and today 500,00 travellers make use of it. Travellers can download this app in their mobile and book services, find places of interest, get a ride from Uber, or use any other app-driven service. It uses the cryptocurrency called CUZ.

Members of Cool Cousin are issued utility tokens that grant them permission to participate in their platform and get access to various services provided. As many people are not aware of the cryptocurrency, Cool Cousin accepts fiat currencies but converts them to CUZ tokens behind the scene. The tokenised smart contracts make the service more trustworthy and efficient for a small transaction fee.

Webjet uses Ethereum on Microsoft Azure for strengthening the data reconciliation service called Rezchain, which is a new technology that enables error-free hotel bookings in real time. Sometimes when bookings are done, discrepancies occur in price, duration of stay, booking status, currency, or room type, leading to invoice disputes between relevant parties. Rezchain warns the parties involved to verify if their reservation data matches with the booking systems, so that it can be fixed early in the booking process. For example, if one side assumes the booking has been cancelled and the other side assumes that the booking is done in their system, Rezchain alarms both the parties, thus making invoicing almost seamless with minimum friction and more efficient. Webjet has travel partners in Europe, Indonesia, China, Southeast Asia, Middle East Africa, North and South America.

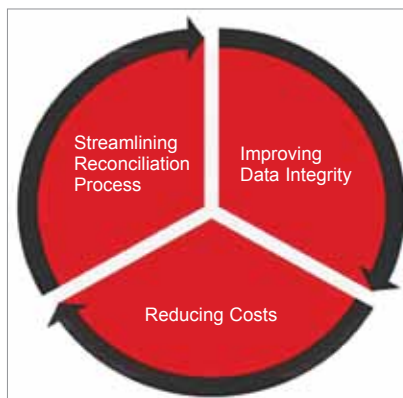


Fig. 4: Efficiency of Rezchain (Image credit: Webbeds)

security, connectivity, and unlimited innovation opportunities. The hotel can choose to accept payments in the form of fiat, credit card, or cryptocurrency (only Lif token or Ether).

Airport Hotel Basel (Switzerland) chain and citizenM Hotel (Malaysia) chain have understood the outstanding benefits of blockchain and hence signed a partnership with Winding Tree not only to foster innovation in the hospitality industry but also to exchange data and transact in a more straightforward, efficient, and transparent way that gets rid of middlemen and associated fees. Winding Tree is not only for giant hotels but even for small hotels, and start-ups who wish to avail the benefits.